



Money Talk Crib Sheet for Couples

Before Marriage or Common-Law Partnership

Use this conversation guide to help determine whether a prenuptial or cohabitation agreement may be appropriate.

1. Current Financial Snapshot

- List all assets (real estate, businesses, investments, pensions, crypto, etc.)
- List all debts (mortgages, loans, credit cards, business liabilities)
- Do either of you own property prior to the relationship?
- Do either of you expect inheritances or family wealth?
- Are there existing trusts or family corporations?

2. Income & Career Trajectory

- Current annual income (both partners)
- Expected career growth or major transitions
- Will one partner pause work for children or caregiving?
- Will one partner support the other through school or business building?

3. Business Ownership & Risk

- Does either partner own a business?
- Are there partners or shareholders involved?
- Would a separation impact business ownership?
- Is there shareholder agreement language already in place?

4. Children & Blended Families

- Are there children from previous relationships?
- How would inheritance be handled?
- Are there support obligations already in place?

5. Financial Values & Philosophy

- Joint vs separate bank accounts?
- Spending and saving styles compatible?
- Debt tolerance differences?
- Investment strategy alignment?

When a Prenup / Cohabitation Agreement Is Strongly Recommended

- Significant asset imbalance between partners
- One partner owns a business
- Family wealth or inheritance is involved
- Children from previous relationships
- High-income disparity
- One partner taking career pause for family

Final Reflection Questions

- If we separated, what would feel fair to both of us?
- What are we trying to protect — and why?
- Would having a written agreement reduce stress or create tension?
- Are we open to seeking independent legal advice?

Financial Education Disclaimer

This document is provided for educational purposes only and does not constitute legal, tax, or financial advice. Marriage, common-law, and property division laws vary by jurisdiction. Couples should consult qualified legal professionals in their province, state, or country before entering into any binding agreement.